

Final Project

Data Science for Environmental Policy

8 October 2026

The final project

- Explore a policy question you care about with data (very broad)
- Teams of 2–3
- Requirements: make a repository from scratch, do an analysis of more than one dataset, and give a 10-minute presentation on your project
- Include a reflection on the limits of your data and analysis, and the equity implications of a data-driven approach to your questions
- Proposal 12 Nov, presentations 17 Dec

Right-size questions

Start from something you care about and a policy that touches it

Combine two or more kinds of data to answer something a decision-maker needs to know

Too big: How does air pollution policy affect health?

Right size: Are Switzerland's protected areas where its threatened species are?

GBIF records + protected area boundaries; informs where to add sites under 30x30

Examples of the right size

- **Policy text:** Do more democratic countries make more specific adaptation commitments in their NDCs?
NDC text + V-Dem
- **Optimization:** Where could Canton Zurich add forest reserves to protect the most bird species for the least land?
GBIF + land cover; Swiss Biodiversity Strategy
- **Causal:** Did fishing effort move to the edges of marine protected areas after they were designated?
Global Fishing Watch + Protected Planet; MPA design

Flexible. Be creative!

A policy brief? A platform (a “show pony”)? Something else?

What we'll look for

- A clear and policy-relevant question
- Reflection on the limits of your analysis and data
- Reproducible repository that someone else could run or use
- A 10-minute presentation

Remember: the course is pass/fail! Make this project something you're excited about!

Start forming ideas!

- Write down an idea, topic, interest, or dataset on sticky notes
- Pitch ideas and form groups
- Scope a question (or a few questions): question, data, methods, expected results
- Explore data that can help answer that question (what exists and what would be ideal)
- Nothing is final (what you brainstorm tonight doesn't need to be your final project)

Schedule for the evening

18:15–19:00: ideas and teams

18:15 Intro to the final project

18:25 Independent writing

18:30 Idea pitches

18:40 Cluster ideas

18:50 Form groups

Break 19:00–19:15

19:15–20:00: working in your groups

19:15 Scope a few questions

19:30 Sketch how you'd answer one

19:45 One-minute shares

19:55 Wrap-up